

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world News Explosion

Reality CHECK

STARANCHORS In the days of Doordarshan, Prannoy Roy with *The World This Week* and the late S.P. Singh with *Aaj Tak* enjoyed celebrity status. The two programmes acted as launchpads for a plethora of new stars who headed other channels.

EKA KAPOOR She was a drifter in her 20s and a millionaire in her 30s. After many flops, Kapoor gave a mega hit in the form of *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*. Many others followed and for nine years Balaji Telefilms reigned.



SMRITI IRANI For a very long time she was known only as Tulsi. Television's favourite *bahu* was a superhero. She forgave adultery, murdered her son and even returned from the dead. She has since tried hard to break the mould, as a politician and an actor, but without much success.



RAKHI SAWANT Many might snigger but Rakhi Sawant's 'Jejus' has stood by her. From item girl to reality queen, Sawant has been taking giant steps. Her success spawned many wannabes like

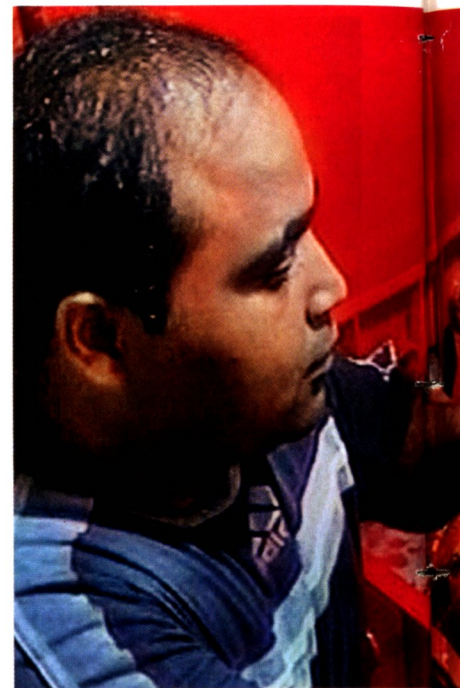
Sherlyn Chopra and Rahul Mahajan, but there's only one that's sipped *Koffee with Karan*.



prime minister Indira Gandhi was always alert to the importance of controlling the dissemination of news in a country marked by low levels of literacy. She expanded the reach of terrestrial television, scrapped tv licences, effected the transition from black-and-white to colour tv in time for the Asian Games, and introduced the National Programme—two hours of news and entertainment, broadcast from Delhi. The idea was to bring the nation together for a few hours of the day, but more importantly, it was to present her government's version of political events. With the arrival of satellite television, Doordarshan's monopoly over the provision of news to the nation crumbled under the pressure of new channels.

The growth of television over the past decade has been phenomenal, and the fastest growth, over the past few years, has been registered in the English-language business news channels and regional news channels. As India undergoes greater global integration, the number of Indians affected by world markets—and who see themselves as global citizens—has risen steadily. They wish to keep abreast of world business news. However, there is an equal and opposite effect to this globalisation as Indians have started to confront this new, borderless world by reconstructing their identities within the boundaries of their local and regional surroundings, just as in Europe, for instance, where the ever greater political union with the EU has given rise to increased regional affiliation and demands for devolution, even independence, such as among the Welsh and Scots in the UK, or the Catalans in Spain.

At a national level, the last two decades have seen the fragmentation of national politics into local or regional, caste-based entities, a shattering that is mirrored in the



BE IT A YOUNG BOY BEING RESCUED OR A GANESHA IDOL DRINKING MILK, THE WEIRD AND THE WONDERFUL FIND A PLACE IN THE NEWS CHANNELS

VIEWERS HAVE SEEN WHAT the reality shows do to people. They are a shortcut to fame, a bloodless revolution.

NIKHIL ALVA,
CEO, MIDITECH

SPIN-OFFS

Small Wonders

Breaking News If it's not breaking, it's not news. Everything from a neighbourhood spat to Abhi-Ash's wedding, even Rakhi Sawant's *swayamvar*, is now urgent news.

Return of Hindi Just when the language was on the verge of disappearing, limiting itself to the corridors of power thanks to BPOs, Hindi fought its way back. Bilingualism became the key as English print journalists found new audiences.

SMS Polls Indian viewers were not content with being just spectators. Opinion polls are now an SMS away. Will Rahul Gandhi be prime minister? Will Saif-Kareena marry? Will 2010 be a good year? Yes or No?

TRP Television Rating Points indicate a TV show's popularity. Channels ask for advertising on the basis of these. The net result, released every Wednesday by Television Audience Measurement, determine plotlines and news skews.